

The Problem of Evil and Book Report

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Dennis Gahm

This paper is regarding the Problem of Evil. This is a classic problem in theology and philosophy, and has many ideas regarding it. The problem is: how can a good God exist if there is evil? Why is there evil in this world if God is all-powerful and good? Couldn't God have prevented evil? In this paper, I want to examine the human's experience of evil as well as the philosophical and academic approach to understanding and reconciling evil with the Christian God. The thesis of this paper is: what is evil, why is there evil, how to reconcile evil with the Christian God, and an examination of the human experience of suffering that causes us to not ask this question theoretically, but ask about evil in an experiential and personal sense that is deeply related to us.

One of the most interesting things I learned about the problem of evil was that evil may have existed in the Garden of Eden even before the fall in Genesis 3, according to Provan¹. The most obvious thing we can take note of is why is there a serpent in the garden in the first place? And why is there a tree of knowledge of good and evil that is forbidden from us to eat? These two questions point to the fact that there was something wrong already from almost the very beginning.

Another interesting thing that shows that something was wrong was that Eve says that we can't even touch the fruit or else we will die. This seems like a small error in her saying because God said that they shall not eat it, lest they die, but it actually shows that Eve was dissatisfied with God and had a grudge against God for not letting them be able to even touch anything or even get close to anything. She was over-exaggerating because she was upset about God.

Other sources talk about the gap theory. This theory says that when it says in the Bible that the earth was formless and void, that angels fell from heaven onto the earth and made the

¹ Provan, Iain. *Discovering Genesis: Content, Interpretation, Reception*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2016.

earth a negative depressive state. The reason for the fall of angels is completely unknown to us, but it could possibly be that Satan wanted to be like God or above God according to the verse in Isaiah. Thus, the answer can be lust, greed, or pride. Another question I can ask is: if creation was very good, is that good enough? Does something have to be perfect in order to be prevented from sinning?

Now that we understand the biblical origin of evil, I want to ask a philosophical question that is extremely straightforward: why did God create evil? My favorite answer is that of John Hicks, who talks of the soul-making theodicy². A theodicy is a theological statement or understanding that allows us to reconcile with the problem of evil. Essentially, what John Hicks' theodicy says is that we have to know evil in order to know good. For example, if we have never been hungry, we will not know what it is to be full or even consider it blessed to be full - we would take it for granted. Thus he says, "The harshness of life gives us a robust texture and character that wouldn't be possible without an imperfect world." John Hicks says that God is building us and training us to become a kind of particular being.

I agree with this view because when we get to heaven, I believe we will remember all of the scars and difficulties we faced, but we would be understanding even more the glory that we have received from it. The simple answer is that evil has a net positive. Also, when we are in heaven, there are two possibilities: we are conscious of hell or we are not conscious of hell. But regardless of our consciousness of hell, I believe God will be conscious of hell, possibly. What I'm trying to say is that hell will be glorious in heaven because we will see evil finally judged and destroyed. We may have a question right now, how can there be evil in this world? The

² Hick, John. *Evil and the God of Love*. New York: Harper & Row, 1966.

Bible says that evil will be completely destroyed and separated from the Christians. There is a victory at the end.

But the victory is not just at the end. Just as John Hicks says, I think that God is forming our character in our lives, even on this side of heaven. By overcoming evil, we are becoming a more glorious person on this earth, and we are able to be more righteous and good. Hume, a famous philosopher says³, “Is he willing to prevent evil, but not able? then he is impotent. Is he able, but not willing? then he is malevolent. Is he both able and willing? whence then is evil?” And from this we can say, does this question really matter? Or does my faith in God and my overcoming of evil actually matter more? Does David Humes' question need to be answered? And did we already answer it by saying that the theodicy is the solution to David's question?

I believe that we all ask about the problem of evil not initially because of some philosophical or theoretical question, but because we have this question out of hurt from evil - personal hurt. And according to Keller⁴, this question of the problem of evil stems from an experiential problem rather than a philosophical problem.

This is the approach of CS Lewis in his book *The Problem of Pain*. Lewis is talking about his and all Christians' problem of pain - their experience with pain, why we have it, and how to overcome it. Isn't this Christian-life oriented approach what we really need? We need pastors, not theoretical academics. In William's paper that compares and contrasts Lewis with Hicks, William says⁵, ‘Lewis's “megaphone theodicy” has significant structural and substantive

³ Hume, David. *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*. Edited by Richard H. Popkin. Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Company, 1998.

⁴ Keller, Timothy. *Walking with God through Pain and Suffering*. New York: Penguin Books, 2013.

⁵Williams, Brian M. “C. S. Lewis & John Hick on Theodicy: Superficially Similar but Significantly Different.” *Journal of Inklings Studies* 7, no. 1 (December 31, 2017): 3–28.

affinities with John Hick's "soul-making" theodicy'. When Lewis publishes his book on the problem of pain, "at this point in his life, he has been a Christian for nearly nine years. [He is] no stranger to pain in his own personal experience." According to history and Williams, he fights for the British army in the World War, contracts trench fever, loses friends, and is seriously wounded by a shell that explodes and kills a fellow soldier right next to him. Lewis witnesses Hitler carrying out his diabolical plan that kills many innocent human lives.

"Lewis' approach to the problem is very much in keeping with the Augustinian approach" (Williams). The reason why Lewis is like Augustine is because he says that Christianity creates, rather than solves, the problem of pain. This is so interesting because you would think that Christianity solves the problem of pain. And I agree with this - if we don't care about good, we would have no conflict with pain. But Christianity says that we have an inner sense of God - a yearning for God - and this makes us hate pain and evil. Christianity creates this problem.

The next person I want to examine regarding this problem is Aquinas. In his *Summa Theologica*⁶, he says that natural evil is necessary for the good of the whole universe. The first thing we have to do in examining this statement is to define what natural evil is. Natural evil is suffering or bad things that result from natural processes, like earthquakes, rather than from the sin of humans.

One debate we can have is: is natural evil ultimately caused from the sin of angels and men? The reason I ask this is because it says in the Bible "through one man, sin entered into the world" (Romans). If we didn't sin, wouldn't the world still be perfect like in the beginning of time? But this debate is a little tangential to this paper, so I will not delve into it.

⁶ Aquinas, Thomas. *Summa Theologiae*. Translated by Fathers of the English Dominican Province. New York: Benziger Bros., 1947.

What I want to focus on is Aquinas' theory on the problem of evil. He uses the Latin term 'poena' to indicate the evil of pain or punishment. 'Culpa' to indicate: the evil of fault or guilt; for example, doing what's wrong against one's conscience. An example that illustrates these words is: suppose a man stole something; this is culpa. Then, he gets put in prison to suffer poena. As we can see, God never wills the culpa, and when he enforces the poena of prison, this poena may actually cause this man to get better and learn from his mistakes.

What we can learn from this analogy is that God never willed evil into the world. It is our choice of culpa to cause evil to enter into the world, and this evil is not to destroy us, but, like prison, to make us better. This directly relates back to John Hick's soul-theodicy, which says that the evil in the world is necessary for the good of the whole universe.

Another theodicy is written by Basil⁷. A Catholic Father explained to me that Basil spoke of something called privation. The Father began to draw a circle, but then stopped $\frac{3}{4}$ of the way, and he ended up drawing part of a circle - an incomplete circle. Now, we can say, "Hey! You made a defective circle! I'm looking to see a circle and you gave me only a part of a circle. This is contrary to all goodness!" But what if the Father had a purpose in drawing only part of a circle. Maybe, he actually wanted you to see that not everything is perfect and what you would like in this world and that he was actually teaching you and introducing you to the Problem of Evil. Then, the partial circle actually has a good purpose in it! It is teaching us. Thus, we can conclude that evil in this world may be a plan of God to show us a higher good. This idea of a partial goodness is called privation (or absence) of good.

⁷ Basil of Caesarea. *The Fathers of the Church: Saint Basil*. Translated by Roy J. Deferrari. Washington, D.C.: Catholic University of America Press, 1950.

Another source that is very good on the Problem of Evil, is, of course, the Bible⁸. The Bible says, “I form the light and create darkness, I bring prosperity and create disaster; I, the LORD, do all these things” (Isaiah 45:7). As we can see, it says that he creates “darkness” and “disaster” - He does “all these things.” This essentially says that God creates evil. Now, that is like a bomb of statement in the delicate and complex arguments of philosophy and theology - God creates evil. Another verse that shows that God creates suffering and negative things, is when God makes King Nebuchadnezzar eat grass and act like an animal. God even kills people in the Old Testament and New. To say that God creates only light or good, is contrary to all these examples.

I understand that God is not the author of chaos or even tempts people (James), but God creates negative things and trials and evil in the sense that he uses it for a good purpose. For example, when God creates darkness, he creates it for the purpose of creating light. And, in the verse above, when he creates “disaster,” he creates it with a telos of goodness. I think this is the emphasis - the telos is goodness. Thus, we can be comforted that any evil we may face is for our good, as Romans 8:28 says, “All things work together for our good.”

This statement - God creates evil - leads us to the next source, I would like to share, which is Dostoevsky’s *The Karamazov Brothers*⁹. In this book, we see a character named Ivan, who is a good Christian. But he realizes that the God he serves causes or allows all the evil in the world - like starving children, World Wars, and utterly terrible things. Ivan realizes that he does not want to go to heaven while the rest of humanity goes through hell on earth and hell in eternity. So, he actually gives up his ticket to heaven because he hates a God that allows evil,

⁸ The Holy Bible, English Standard Version. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2016.

⁹ Dostoevsky, Fyodor. *The Karamazov Brothers*. Translated by David McDuff. London: Penguin Classics, 2003.

and goes to hell. This story is directly related with the previous paragraph in this paper, in that we stated that God creates evil. Now, whether or not God directly creates evil, we can disagree - but we can all agree like Ivan in the story, that God allows terrible evil in the world and in eternity. Thus, we need to ask ourselves, “Is God still the same loving God that I’ve loved all my life, even with all the evils I see in this world?” And the answer to this is: God is the same as in the Old Testament, where terrible things happened to people. Whether we understand God or not is a secondary matter; the primary matter is, “Do you fear God and want to be on his good side and not on his wrathful side?”

Another corollary to this topic of God being the author of evil is: “You think God doesn’t know about the evil in the world and that he has no sorrow over it? You, Ivan, do you think you are some noble man to go to hell? Do you think that God doesn’t care about your pain or the nature of suffering or evil?”

Untea¹⁰ provides an answer to these questions, an answer, which in summary is: Jesus and God suffered all of the evil and nailed it to the cross so that we can enjoy heaven. In the words of Untea, “God fully shares the pain of the world.” Does God desire us to “worship a crucified Christ, should think that it is raw power which earns worship.” In other words, does God want us to worship a deity who is agnostic to good or bad only to worship just this being who is super powerful and raw in its power?

What we see is that “the entire divine being is seen as connected not only with the suffering of every human, but also deeply connected to the suffering of nature.” God understands and shares with the pain of every scratch a child may feel. So, “God hurts with us...and has far more motive than we do to prevent or ease suffering in the world.”

¹⁰ Untea, Ionut. “From the Aesthetic Theme to the Aesthetic Myth: A Reflection on the Trinitarian God’s Connection to Nature and the Problem of Evil.” *Sophia* 61, no. 4

As we can see, God deeply cares about us and our suffering, and God even shows it with his actions because he died on the cross to take away hell from us. As I learned in my Trinity class at Faith Seminary, I see that we are cursed because of Adam's sin, but Christ became sin for me who knew no sin. Jesus experienced every hurt and pain that we ever had or will have. And so, if anyone is upset about the fact that there is evil in the world, it is God.

Up to this point in the paper, I described 10 sources that are academic and relate to the problem of evil. From this point forward in the paper, I want to include my thoughts on the problem of Evil. One of the main thoughts that I want to write about is that soul-theodicy is a theory that I truly resonate with. Sometimes, when we are going through great difficulty, it helps to know why this suffering is occurring, and what we can get out of it when we finally pass and overcome this trial. And the soul-theodicy theory helps me to do those two things - know why, and know what I can get out of it.

The why and telos of the problem of evil is very interesting. Hick says that evil is here because it will develop us into a better person. Thus, as the Bible says, "Once I get through this fire of trial, I will come out as pure gold." We see that through the trial, we will gain a lot of character, and as Romans states it, we will gain "glory, honor, and immortality." We may not completely understand the philosophy of the problem of evil, but the Bible clearly states that we are to fight sin, and rejoice always. Evil buffets us everyday - at the workplace, in our families, and in our own selves. Although we may not know the ultimate reason, we know we are in the spiritual war - a war of God's good against Satan's evil. It is absolutely stupid to think that our reasoning should cause us to turn to Satan and hell because our rationality says God is evil or not worth it. This is the story of Ivan. We must stay in the battle and fight for the salvation of ourselves, and the salvation of others.

It would be a great sin to ponder all the philosophical thoughts of Evil and not do a single thing to make the actual evil lesser. We need to actually solve the problem of Evil with our faith in Jesus Christ! We need to go out and make disciples and serve other people and share God's love. This is the purpose of this Apologetics class. We are not studying all this philosophy in order to have a coffee-debate on all the ins and outs of the argument - people's eternal destinies are at stake!

One of the purposes of learning about the Problem of Evil is that it is the biggest cause of people to deny the faith. When they want to place faith in God, Satan comes along and says, "How can you believe in a God who didn't stop evil? You see all the evil you had to face? If God was real, he would have protected you and stopped that evil from happening to you. Don't believe in God!" And from this, we must say, "Yes, Satan, I understand. But I understand even more that God is beyond my comprehension and that in order to do what's right and be right, I must believe! My salvation is at stake! I don't care what arguments you have, I will believe God just because!"

And this leads us to one of the core truths in my theology - "I believe, just because." There is no reason why I believe; there is no ulterior motive. There is nothing complex about the foundation or root of my belief. Even a child can understand it and believe. When I am in coma and am 100 years old, my faith does not rest on my intellect or rationality explaining everything - I will just believe. I will just believe. God is my rock and foundation, and he will save me."

This is similar to the faith of Job. Even if you give Job hell, he will still contend with God as Israel - wrestling with God. We will always wrestle with God. This is also known as asking, seeking, and knocking. God is holy and perfect, so he is different from us; but he is also God and the holder of every blessing and thing we can possibly want. Thus, we are separate

from God as unholy, but we go to God and wrestle with him in order to get the goodness and blessing. To fail to wrestle with God is to just accept failure and to be stagnant and die in the war. We have to keep active and vigilant, and correct ourselves always, and seek to bless our enemies and others.

When a newspaper asked people to write in about what they think is the cause of the problem of evil, one famous author simply wrote-in, "Me." This means that the author himself is the cause of the problem of evil. Now, you may joke, as long as we simply eliminate this man from existence, we will solve the problem of evil. But what he is indicating is a fundamental issue - each of us, even I, am a cause to the evil in this world. The next entailment is: how can we solve the problem of evil? Me. Now that just means, place all the burden of solving the problem on that guy as well. What this second Me would mean is that we all have the burden and obligation to be a better person, a better citizen, and a better blessing every day. The love that we seek, the people we desire to be with - all these things that we fundamentally need to stay emotionally healthy, and mentally healthy, are the things that we should offer and understand about other people.

This leads us to understand that through this degree at Faith Seminary, we will be the light of the world, and salt of the earth. The Bible is the true light and answer. Jesus says, "I am the way and the truth and the life." We need to share this with people, and being a well informed theologian or philosopher will help people to understand the faith more, and then actually believe.

So, what does it take to make someone believe? Actually this is the work of the Holy Spirit to give faith to people and save them. Thus, we can only humbly do our best work and sincerely lift it up to God. But we definitely need to forget earthly motives and things, like

“How can I make money for my family? How can I get this degree? How can I have a fulfilling life in the future?” God says in Mathew’s Sermon on the Mount, “I know you need all these things! First, seek the Kingdom of God and His Righteousness, and all these things will be given to you.”

And so we see that in the big scope of things, evangelism and apologetics is only one piece of the puzzle. We need to serve the King and when we focus on that, all our philosophy will be correct and people’s defenses will go down.

More than anything in the world, we need faith working itself out in love. It is a difficult journey, and evil is along the way, but love, faith, and hope abide forever, and if it is true you have eternal life, what that means is that light in you will never fail or disappear - you will overcome with the blood of the lamb and will defeat evil. Yes, you will defeat Evil! It is not a problem of evil, it is a small part in your life and you will face evil and defeat it and be joyful and victorious. The Christian doesn’t have a problem of evil, he has eternal, good life.

In conclusion, there are lots of academic thought that has gone into the problem of Evil. But to the Christian, there is no problem of evil, there is only a glory of overcoming evil and a promise of eternal life. Evil is only a problem if you are looking at a worldly perspective - but a heavenly perspective keeps its focus and eyes on God and goodness, and does not dwell on evil. Even Paul the Apostle wished for death when he was in great difficulty. And we too will face great difficulty. But we fight from victory, not for victory, and we will satisfy the prophecy of Revelation, “They overcame with the blood of the Lamb.” Let us remember the great suffering and evil that Jesus faced on Good Friday, and worship the Lamb forever and ever.

Appendix

This class was a very interesting class. I personally learned a lot from the textbooks, and felt that the lectures were asking the questions I would ask. One of the things that I really liked about our textbook, Reason for Hope, was that it was very philosophical and scientific. It actually argued in a way that the secular academics at Harvard would answer. The logic and reasoning was understandable, and seemed pretty solid. I personally think that the reasoning was not perfect or always right because apologetics can be answered in many different ways.

However, the bottom line was that I really enjoyed this class. The one topic that stood out for me was the problem of evil. This problem truly is a problem and is the number one reason why people have trouble with Christianity. It's so interesting that Thomas Aquinas and Augustine could not settle the problem or solve the problem completely. And I find the theodicies that are created in order to satisfy this dilemma to be interesting and profound. Would the world be better off without evil? Maybe not. The soul theodicy says that our souls mature through overcoming and experiencing evil. This topic is one of those topics that my mother would caringly explain because any Christian, smart or not, will have an answer (or thoughts) to this question.

The reason I chose the problem of evil for my essay was that I wanted to research all the different answers to this problem, and analyze and examine these positions and form my own answer.

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